Song Form 101: The 12-Bar Blues

History of the blues

- Born in slavery on the Mississippi delta,
- Blues emerged from African American field hollers, work songs, spirituals
- Mixed with Afro-Caribbean and European music in New Orleans to give rise to jazz, Zydeco and Cajun
- Music moved along with freed people in the Great Migration up the Mississippi through Memphis and on to Chicago and all points between. It mixed with European-American big band and mountain music giving rise to country, rhythm and blues, an rock and roll
- 12-bar form is most common blues song structure
- Swing rhythm (12/8 shuffle) with "push beats"

Harmonic structure: I-IV-V, but different

- Starts with the I-IV-V of European classical diatonic harmony, but breaks a lot of rules
    - The I and IV chords are usually played as seventh (dominant) chords
    - "blue notes": minor third, flat fifth, and flat (dominant) seventh. The "blues scale" is a pentatonic minor scale with the addition of a flat five.

The 12-bar song form

- Three lines, each with four bars
    - First line centers on the 1 chord
    - Second line centers on the 4
    - Third line centers on the 5, with a "turnaround" (cadence) leading harmonically back to the top
- There are many variations, but a typical 12-bar blues looks like this, with **all chords played as sevenths**:

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|E(1)|A(4)              |E(1)|E(1)|
C'mon     Baby dontcha wanna go                C'-
|A(4)|A(4)              |E(1)|E(1)|
 -mon     Baby dontcha wanna go          back to the
|B(5)       |A(4)     |E(1)|B(5)|
  Eleven light city, sweet home chicago
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